

EVER COMMONS

Founding Blueprint

A sustainable digital commons for social media, creators, contributors, infrastructure partners, and public benefit.

THE DIGITAL ECOSYSTEM THAT GIVES BACK

Working concept - Version 0.1

21 August 2026

Open by design. Private by architecture. Sustainable by economics.



FOUNDING DECISION

Recommended working name: **EverCommons**

The digital ecosystem that gives back.

The idea in one sentence

EverCommons is a commercially sustainable digital commons: polished social applications funded by privacy-preserving ads, optional subscriptions, donations and aligned partners, with transparent revenue sharing for creators, open-source contributors, infrastructure providers and public-benefit causes.

Social First product short-form video and profiles	No sale of data Core promise contextual ads, no surveillance graph	1% revenue Public commitment verified environmental/public benefit
Capacity first Growth rule waitlist before degraded service	No lock-in Ownership rule portable data and replaceable providers	Live well Founder rule fair pay without extraction-first governance

What this document decides

- The project is an ecosystem, not merely an open-source Instagram or TikTok clone.
- The flagship product should be EverCommons Social, while future apps remain optional and evidence-gated.
- The service can run advertisements, but targeting must be contextual and privacy-preserving rather than based on cross-site surveillance.
- Creators, contributors and infrastructure partners should participate in transparent revenue pools governed by published formulas.
- Infrastructure support is welcome from open-source or proprietary companies, but no provider may become irreplaceable or gain ownership of user data.
- Growth pauses when technical, financial, moderation or support capacity becomes unsafe. The waitlist is an operational control, not manufactured scarcity.
- A benefit company can pay the founder and team well. Mission assets should ultimately be protected by an independent foundation or equivalent steward structure.

Status and limitations

This is a founding blueprint, not legal, tax, securities, employment, privacy or financial advice. The name is a provisional recommendation based on a limited web collision screen. Obtain Italian and EU legal advice, formal trademark searches, domain checks, app-store checks and a financial model before public launch.

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1. Executive thesis

The proposition

EverCommons should be built as a self-funding digital commons rather than as a conventional growth-at-all-costs social-media startup. The goal is not to remove commerce from social media. The goal is to make commerce compatible with privacy, openness, fair compensation, public benefit and user freedom.

The platform can show clearly labelled sponsored advertising, offer an ad-free subscription, facilitate creator sponsorships and accept donations or grants. What it refuses is the surveillance bargain: collecting intimate behavioural histories, combining them across services, selling or brokering personal data, or making privacy a premium-only feature.

Signal demonstrates the central economic reality: a polished privacy-preserving service still requires substantial infrastructure and skilled labour. Signal reported tens of millions of dollars in annual costs and an estimated USD 50 million annual operating requirement by 2025. The lesson is not that alternatives are impossible. It is that the costs must be named, funded and governed transparently. [R01]

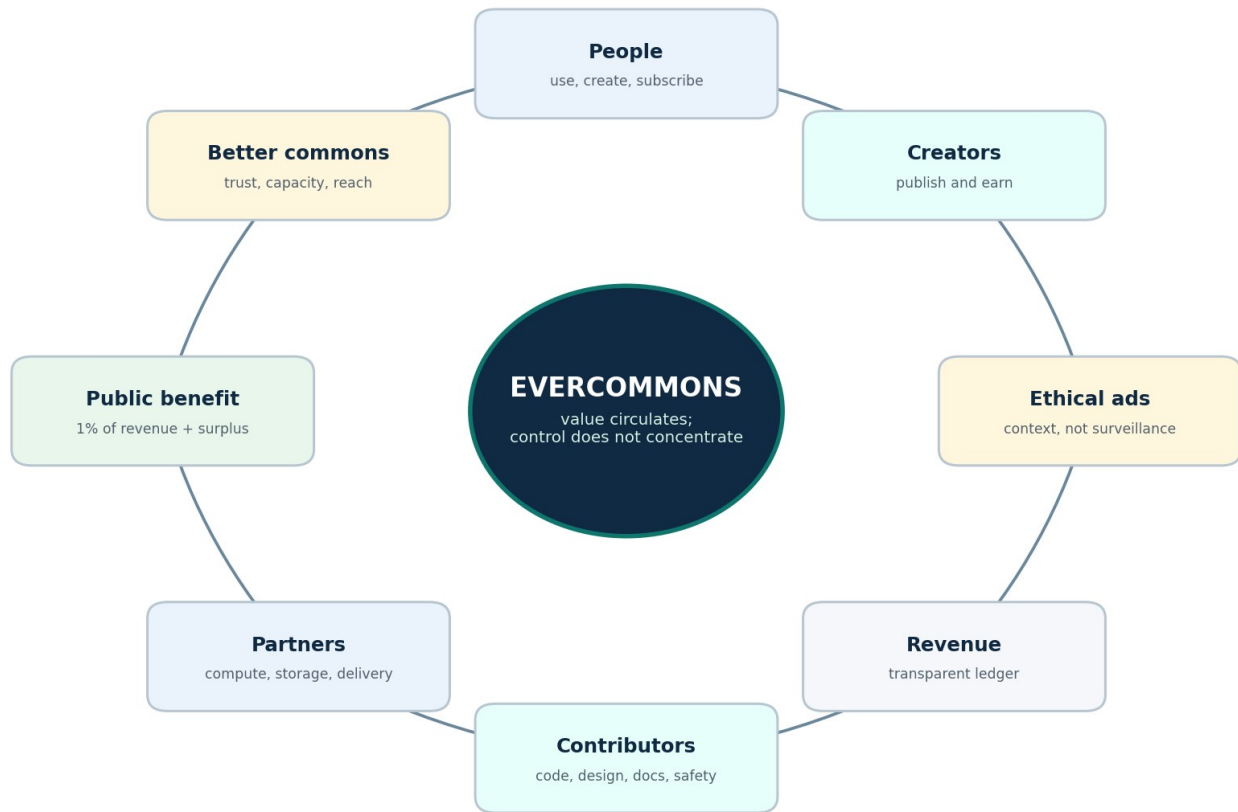
The strategic wedge

Do not ask creators to abandon incumbents

The launch message is: "Keep your YouTube, Instagram and TikTok accounts. Cross-post here and help prove a better model." This removes the creator's immediate economic risk and turns participation into support for a movement rather than an exclusivity demand.

The first product should be a polished, invitation-only short-video and social application with excellent playback, a following feed, transparent discovery, creator dashboards, contextual sponsor ads, strong moderation and a public capacity dashboard. It should not begin with live streaming, private messaging, a commercial music catalogue, children, global federation or a frontier AI model.

The economic loop



Value is designed to circulate through the ecosystem instead of concentrating in one platform owner.

Users create demand and attention. Creators supply culture and knowledge. Advertisers and subscribers fund the service. The platform allocates revenue to creators, infrastructure, contributors, safety, employees, reserves and verified public-benefit causes. Those investments improve product quality and capacity, which attracts more people and aligned partners. The loop is sustainable only if every allocation is understandable, auditable and reversible when a partner stops delivering value.

What success means

- A normal person can install the app and use it without understanding federation, hosting or open-source terminology.
- A creator can see how each revenue stream is calculated and can export content and records.
- A contributor can be paid for durable work, not only for code volume.
- A hosting company can contribute infrastructure and receive transparent value without owning the network.
- The founder and employees can live securely and travel, rest and build a life without turning users into assets.
- The project can be copied or extended by others without destroying the mission. A successful compatible fork is evidence that the commons is working.

The first hard corrections

Tempting statement	Operationally sound version
"Everything will be free."	Core access can be free to users; infrastructure, labour, safety, legal compliance and payments still have real costs.
"GitHub or Signal automatically supports us."	They may be listed only as Built With or Inspired By. Official Partner requires explicit permission and a signed agreement.
"No telemetry at all."	No behavioural surveillance telemetry. Minimal, short-lived operational, security and abuse telemetry is necessary and should be documented.
"Encrypted public video means servers cannot see it."	Public video can be encrypted in transit and at rest, but content intended for public viewing, transcoding and moderation is not Signal-style end-to-end secret.
"A waitlist filters out bad people."	A waitlist controls capacity. Safety rules, moderation, rate limits and appeals manage harmful behaviour.
"Give a provider 5% forever."	Use a dynamic infrastructure pool based on verified contribution. Never grant perpetual revenue rights or mission control to a vendor.
"Contributors will automatically arrive."	A meaningful mission helps, but people respond to credible prototypes, concrete tasks, good governance and respectful maintenance.

Decision discipline

The movement should remain ambitious without confusing hope with a plan. Every public promise should be translated into an operating rule, a measurable signal and a decision gate before it becomes part of the product or partner pitch.

Promise -> rule Translate the idea name the owner, cost and boundary	Rule -> metric Make it observable publish evidence, not slogans	Metric -> gate Protect the mission pause, continue or change course
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Founding standard

The project may begin small and imperfect. It must not begin by making claims it cannot measure, fund or keep.

Mission and founding constitution

Mission

Mission statement

Build a high-quality digital ecosystem in which people can communicate, create and earn without surrendering privacy or becoming dependent on a single technology corporation; and ensure that the ecosystem's success rewards the people and public goods that make it possible.

EverCommons is not anti-business, anti-advertising or anti-profit. It is anti-extraction, anti-lock-in and anti-surveillance. Commercial actors are welcome when they add measurable value under common rules. Profit is allowed to fund stable lives, skilled teams, resilience and expansion. The governance system prevents profit maximisation from overriding the mission.

Twelve constitutional principles

Principle	Meaning in practice
Privacy for everyone	Privacy is not a premium feature. Free users receive the same baseline privacy protections as paying users.
No surveillance business model	No sale of personal data, no cross-site tracking, no hidden data-broker enrichment and no sensitive-trait targeting.
Open core	The essential server, client and protocol components remain open source under licences selected with counsel.
Portability and exit	Users can export content, account records and social relationships in documented formats. Providers have tested migration paths.
Transparent economics	Revenue definitions, allocation formulas, material adjustments and aggregate payouts are published and independently reviewed.
Creators share value	Creators receive a defined share of eligible content revenue and keep ownership of their work, subject to licences they choose to grant.
Contributors share value	Code, maintenance, documentation, accessibility, design, translation, security and community work can qualify for compensation.
Capacity before growth	Registration pauses before performance, safety, support or cash reserves become unsafe.
Replaceable infrastructure	Every critical vendor has an exit plan. No provider owns the social graph, user data or recommendation policy.
Safety with due process	Reporting, reasoned decisions, appeals, age-appropriate design and transparency are product requirements, not later add-ons.
Public benefit	At least 1% of annual revenue is committed to verified environmental or public-interest organisations, supplemented by excess-surplus rules.

Principle	Meaning in practice
Mission beyond founders	Constitutional changes require independent oversight, public notice and a supermajority. A future CEO cannot quietly reverse the model.

A movement with an operational discipline

The movement language matters because it recruits people around a shared future. The operating discipline matters because inspirational projects fail when they ignore cash flow, abuse, maintenance, rights management or governance. EverCommons should publish both: a simple public manifesto and a detailed operating constitution.

- The manifesto explains why the project exists in plain language.
- The constitution defines non-negotiable rules and the process for changing them.
- The product roadmap defines what is being built now and what is deliberately excluded.
- The economic policy defines revenue terms before money is distributed.
- The transparency reports prove whether the organisation is following its promises.

European strategic context

The proposal is aligned with a broader European direction, although it is not affiliated with any government programme. In December 2025, the European Commission described the Digital Commons EDIC as a structure bringing public administrations, open-source communities and companies together to pool resources, support strategic open components and reduce dependency on a small number of global platforms. Italy is among its founding members. [R17]

	Positioning opportunity EverCommons can present itself as a consumer-facing demonstration of European digital commons principles: open components, shared infrastructure, data protection, commercial participation and technological sovereignty. Do not claim endorsement or programme membership without formal acceptance.
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3. The first product

Product name and role

The umbrella project should use the provisional name EverCommons. The first consumer product can use the descriptive working name EverCommons Social until a separate consumer brand is justified. Future names such as EverCommons Chat, Cloud, Meet or AI should remain reserved concepts, not parallel development commitments.

Initial audience

- Creators willing to cross-post original short videos and explain the mission to their existing audiences.
- Privacy-conscious users who still expect mainstream-quality design and performance.
- Open-source developers, designers, translators, safety specialists and infrastructure engineers.
- Ethical brands that want contextual advertising and measurable public-benefit association without data-broker targeting.
- European universities, public-interest organisations, hosting providers and cooperatives interested in digital sovereignty.

Minimum lovable product

Capability	MVP decision	Reason
Accounts	Email or passkey, profile, recovery, export	Simple onboarding without making a phone number mandatory.
Video	Vertical upload, processing, adaptive playback, captions, thumbnails	The product must prove a polished core experience.
Social graph	Follow/unfollow, profile, likes, comments	Enough network mechanics to build community.
Feeds	Following, chronological and one transparent discovery feed	Choice from day one; avoid one opaque mandatory ranking system.
Creator tools	Analytics, revenue shadow ledger, export, sponsorship disclosure	Creators must see the economics before payouts scale.
Advertising	Direct-sold contextual sponsor cards, clearly labelled	Test economics without surveillance or a complex real-time ad exchange.
Safety	Report, block, mute, moderation queue, decision reasons, appeals	Safety is part of capacity, not a later policy page.
Capacity	Waitlist, invite cohorts, public capacity dashboard	Growth follows resources and service quality.
Transparency	Status, costs, provider concentration and allocation dashboard	Trust is demonstrated through evidence.

Explicit exclusions from the first release

- No live streaming. It multiplies moderation, latency and rights risks.
- No private messaging. Add it later with a dedicated end-to-end encrypted design rather than a rushed chat feature.
- No commercial music catalogue. Start with original audio, public-domain material and properly licensed or Creative Commons audio.
- No minors in the first public pilot. Begin with an 18+ closed alpha while age-assurance, child safety and youth design are developed with specialists.

- No cryptocurrency or token. Use a conventional auditable ledger and normal payments unless a later problem genuinely requires another mechanism.
- No global federation write path. Export and portability come first; interoperability follows after product and abuse controls are stable.
- No attempt to train a frontier foundation model. Use replaceable models or simple algorithms only where they add measurable value.

Experience quality is a constitutional requirement

The project cannot rely on ideological sympathy to compensate for a poor product. Open source should be invisible to a normal user unless they choose to inspect or contribute. Performance budgets should be release gates, not aspirations.

Area	Proposed product target
Playback	Warm video starts feel immediate; p75 network starts under 1.5 seconds on the defined mid-range test device and network profile.
Scrolling	No visible jank in the primary feed; frame-time and dropped-frame budgets measured on mid-range Android and iOS hardware.
Reliability	Crash-free sessions above 99.5% before public expansion.
Accessibility	WCAG 2.2 AA web target, screen-reader labels, captions, text scaling, keyboard paths and reduced-motion mode.
Transparency	Every ad has a visible sponsor label and a "Why this ad?" explanation.
Control	Following and chronological feeds remain available; autoplay and recommendation controls are easy to find.
Data export	A user can request a machine-readable export without contacting support.

Creator acquisition

	Launch invitation "Do not leave the platforms that currently pay you. Cross-post a small part of your work here. Help us prove that a free-to-use social network can pay creators without selling its users."
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Recruit the first 20 creators individually. Provide white-glove upload support, import tools where lawful, clear rights terms and a public founding-creator page. Do not promise income before revenue exists. Use a shadow ledger to show what payouts would have been under the published formula, then activate real payments only after fraud, tax, KYC and cash-reserve controls are ready.

4. Open economics and revenue allocation

Open-source the business model

Publishing source code is not enough. EverCommons should publish the definitions that determine who receives money, the aggregate ledger that records those decisions, the provider valuation method, the contributor scoring process and the governance procedure for changing them.

Current creator platforms already use distinct revenue-share formulas. YouTube currently states that eligible partners receive 55% of net Watch Page ad revenue and 45% of their allocated Shorts creator-pool revenue, while fan-funding products use another rate. These percentages cannot be compared responsibly without the definitions, rights costs, fraud rules and revenue base behind them. EverCommons should therefore compete on clarity, not on one headline percentage. [R02]

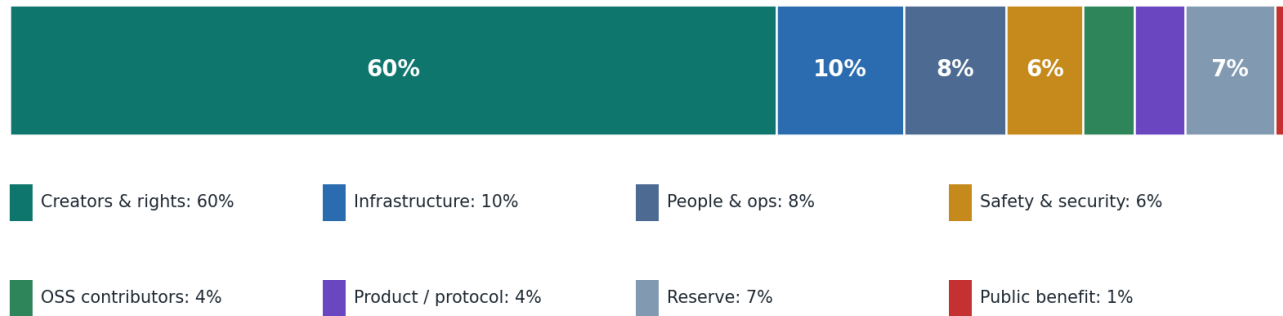
Revenue streams

Revenue stream	Recommended treatment
Contextual platform ads	Share eligible content revenue with creators through a published formula; allocate the operator portion to infrastructure, contributors, people, safety, reserves and public benefit.
Ad-free subscription	Allocate a creator pool based on eligible watch time or another published attention measure, with privacy-preserving aggregation.
Creator sponsorship marketplace	Creator keeps a high share; platform charges a transparent facilitation, safety, measurement and payment fee.
Direct tips	Creator receives at least 90% after unavoidable payment, tax, refund and fraud costs; exact jurisdictional treatment requires counsel.
Donations to the project	Use only for the purposes disclosed to donors; do not pretend a restricted grant is ordinary operating revenue.
Infrastructure sponsorship	Record capacity and fair-market value separately from cash revenue; never inflate donated retail list prices.
Managed hosting or enterprise services	Commercial ecosystem revenue can fund the commons while the protocol and core remain open.

A proposed revenue waterfall

Illustrative allocation of EUR100 eligible content revenue

After taxes, refunds, payment fees, fraud adjustments and direct content-rights pass-throughs.



This is a design target for testing, not a binding promise. The charter should define formulas, floors and change controls.

Illustrative EUR100 allocation for discussion and testing. It is deliberately explicit about the revenue base.

The diagram uses EUR100 of eligible content revenue after VAT or sales tax, refunds, payment processing, fraud adjustments and direct content-rights pass-throughs. It proposes EUR60 for creators and rights participants. The remaining EUR40 funds the operating ecosystem, including EUR1 for the public-benefit commitment. This is a target model, not a promise that should be adopted before cost testing.

Recommended policy architecture

- Target creator share: 60% of eligible content revenue during the pilot.
- Constitutional creator floor: never below 50% without creator-council approval, foundation approval, a public impact analysis and at least 90 days notice.
- Direct tips: at least 90% to the creator after unavoidable pass-through deductions.
- Sponsorship marketplace: target 85% creator / 15% platform after direct pass-through deductions.
- Public benefit: 1% of annual company revenue, funded from the operator share rather than deducted from the creator share.
- Excess surplus: after obligations, a defined reserve and approved investment plan, at least half of remaining annual distributable surplus should flow to the foundation, ecosystem grants or verified public-benefit causes.

Definitions must come before percentages

Term	Draft definition
Gross receipts	Cash actually received from customers, advertisers, subscribers, sponsors, donors and other sources, separated by type.
Pass-through deductions	VAT/sales tax, refunds, payment fees, chargebacks, confirmed invalid traffic and directly attributable third-party rights costs.
Eligible content revenue	Content-linked gross receipts minus only the published pass-through deductions. Salaries and ordinary hosting are not hidden deductions before the creator share.
Creator pool	The amount allocated to eligible creators under the published formula, including clear treatment of collaborations and rights holders.

Term	Draft definition
Operator share	The remainder used for infrastructure, staff, safety, contributors, product, reserve and public benefit.
Distributable surplus	Audited profit remaining after tax, contractual obligations, creator/contributor liabilities, minimum reserve and approved operating investment.

Contributor compensation

Contributor compensation should not be based on lines of code, raw commit count or popularity. Those metrics reward fragmentation and are easy to manipulate. Begin with grants and bounties, then introduce an Impact Credit system once governance capacity exists.

Contribution dimension	Examples	Weighting principle
Impact	Resolved severe defect, improved playback, reduced cost, increased accessibility	Measured outcome and user benefit.
Criticality	Security, database reliability, payment ledger, moderation tooling	Higher weight for risk-bearing components.
Durability	Maintenance, review, release work, dependency care	Reward continued stewardship, not one-time novelty.
Community value	Documentation, translation, onboarding, issue triage, design systems	Recognise non-code work explicitly.
Quality	Tests, review quality, threat models, backward compatibility	Reward work that reduces future maintenance.
Integrity	Conflict disclosure, respectful conduct, security handling	Eligibility requires compliance with community standards.

A quarterly committee with contributor-elected members should propose allocations. Decisions, rationales, conflicts and appeals should be public. Anti-Sybil controls, concentration caps and independent audits are required before the pool becomes material.

Founder and employee sustainability

Doing good must not require precarity

The founder should receive a fair salary once the project can support it. Employees and long-term maintainers should be paid competitively enough to build reliable infrastructure. Personal security, healthcare, rest and reasonable travel are legitimate project costs.

- Set a founder minimum-living threshold and a stage-appropriate compensation band approved by independent directors.
- Publish compensation policy and aggregate executive bands rather than relying on personal sacrifice as governance.
- Do not pay dividends or extraordinary founder bonuses while creator liabilities are unpaid, reserves are below policy or safety staffing is inadequate.
- Do not grant a founder, vendor or investor a perpetual percentage of total revenue.

- Use mission-locked equity, capped returns or steward-ownership mechanisms after specialist legal design.

Public-benefit commitment

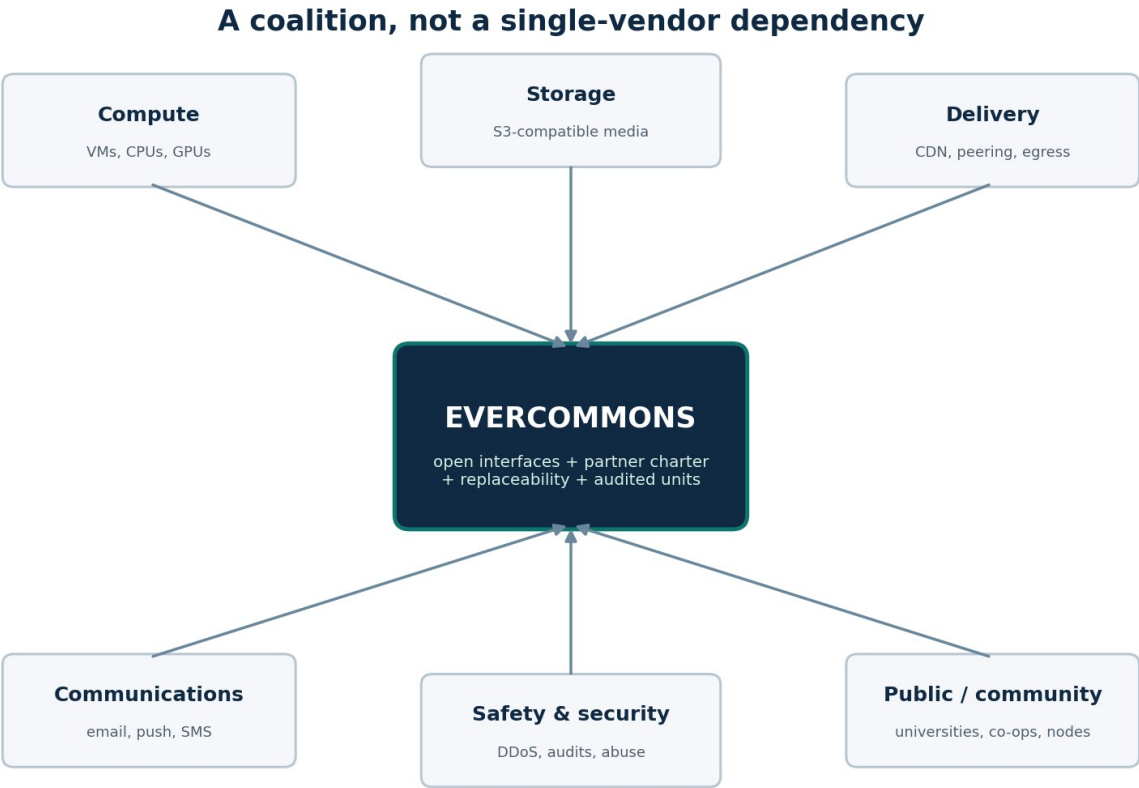
A percentage of revenue is harder to manipulate than a percentage of accounting profit. The existing 1% for the Planet model is an example of businesses contributing 1% of annual sales or revenue to environmental organisations and certifying those contributions. EverCommons can adopt its own broader public-benefit policy or seek recognised certification after legal and financial review. [R14]

Allocation concept	Illustrative share of the 1% fund
Climate mitigation and restoration	40%
Air quality and environmental health	20%
Hunger, essential needs and disaster response	20%
Open digital public infrastructure	10%
Independent privacy, safety and environmental research	10%

Recipients should be selected through published criteria, conflict checks, geographic diversity and evidence of impact. No donation should be used to excuse avoidable emissions, unsafe design or exploitative labour.

5. Infrastructure partner coalition

The coalition model



Partners contribute value; none receives permanent equity, user data ownership, or mission control.

Multiple providers can join under common rules; no single sponsor becomes the platform.

EverCommons should invite companies, universities, cooperatives, datacentres and public institutions to contribute compute, storage, delivery, security, communications or expertise. Participation is not charity-only. A provider may gain revenue-pool payments, public attribution, developer goodwill, customer visibility and evidence of public benefit. The exchange must be explicit and fair.

Partner categories

Category	Meaning	What may be claimed publicly
Built With	A technology or service the project uses under ordinary terms.	"Built with X" only; no implication of endorsement.
Inspired By	A project whose principles or design informed the work.	"Inspired by Signal / ActivityPub / PeerTube" with accurate context.
Community Contributor	A person or organisation has contributed code, design, documentation or other work.	Specific contribution and date.
Capacity Sponsor	An organisation has donated or discounted a defined service or funded a capacity milestone.	Verified capacity or value contributed and period covered.
Certified Partner	A signed agreement binds the provider to privacy, portability, security, measurement and exit terms.	Official partner status for the contracted scope only.
Founding Partner	A certified partner made an early material contribution under the same mission constraints.	Founding recognition without ownership of the commons.

Two infrastructure participation tracks

Track	Mechanism	Safeguard
Sponsor track	Provider donates credits, hardware, bandwidth, expertise or cash for a defined period or capacity goal.	Recognition is proportional and time-bounded. No guaranteed revenue or governance right.
Revenue-share track	Provider signs a service agreement and earns from the Infrastructure Pool according to verified contribution units.	Quarterly recalibration, fair-market-value cap, SLA, portability, audit and termination rights.

Legal form of partner payment

Treat any Infrastructure Pool allocation as capped contractual consideration for verified services - not equity, a dividend, a deposit, a token or an indefinite profit right. Italian and EU tax, VAT, accounting, procurement, employment and securities counsel should approve the structure before money is promised.

Infrastructure Contribution Units

Draft formula

Contribution Units = verified fair-market value x delivered-service factor x reliability factor x portability factor x geographic-diversity factor x sustainability factor. The payment is the lower of the provider's pool share and a contractual cap based on audited delivered value.

- Verified fair-market value uses comparable wholesale quotes, not an inflated public list price.
- Delivered-service factor excludes unused credits and failed capacity.
- Reliability factor reflects measured availability, support response and incident performance.
- Portability factor rewards standard interfaces, documented export and successful migration tests.
- Geographic-diversity factor rewards resilience and useful regional coverage rather than duplicate capacity.
- Sustainability factor uses disclosed energy, carbon, water and hardware-life evidence; marketing claims alone receive no multiplier.
- No partner payment survives contract termination except already accrued and verified amounts.

Partner Charter essentials

- No ownership, sale or independent use of user data.
- Data processing limited to the contracted service, documented subprocessors and EU-compliant terms where applicable.
- No exclusivity that prevents migration or multi-provider operation.
- Standard interfaces and tested exit procedures, including deletion certification.
- Security incident notification, audit rights and coordinated vulnerability handling.
- No use of project data or content to train AI models without a separate, explicit and lawful agreement.
- No governance power proportional to infrastructure spend; providers may advise but cannot purchase the mission.
- Transparent statement of what was contributed, for how long and with what service limits.

Bootstrap reality

Provider programmes can reduce early costs, but they are conditional and temporary. Vercel currently advertises an open-source programme with USD 3,600 of platform credits over twelve months for selected projects. DigitalOcean offers startup credits through approved partners with limits and eligibility conditions. These are useful bridges, not permanent infrastructure promises. [R03] [R04]

The landing site can begin on a free static tier and the public repository can use free public-repository tooling. The moment the project handles real user data or media, it needs budgets, backups, security controls and an exit path. Never design the business on the assumption that a free tier will remain unlimited.

6. Privacy-preserving advertising

Advertising without a surveillance profile

EverCommons should sell context, not people. The primary ad inputs should be the content currently being viewed, language, coarse jurisdiction where legally necessary, campaign suitability, frequency controls and user-declared preferences. The system should not import broker data, follow users across websites or infer sensitive traits for targeting.

Allowed and prohibited signals

Signal or practice	Decision	Explanation
Video category and topic	Allowed	A camera advertisement beside photography content is contextual.
Language	Allowed	Needed for relevance and campaign delivery.
Coarse country/region	Limited	Use only when necessary for availability, law or campaign scope; avoid precise location.
User-selected interests	Opt-in	Store locally where practical and make reset controls obvious.
Cross-site browsing history	Prohibited	Not necessary for contextual advertising.
Data-broker enrichment	Prohibited	Creates opaque profiles and external dependency.
Device fingerprinting	Prohibited	Do not reconstruct identity through covert technical signals.
Sensitive categories	Prohibited	No targeting based on health, sexuality, religion, political belief or similar traits.
Profiling minors	Prohibited	EU rules prohibit profiling/personal-data based ad targeting of minors.
Public engagement history	Restricted	Do not create a durable advertising dossier; use aggregate or on-device approaches only after review.

Recommended ad flow

1. Advertiser submits creative, landing page, budget, country/language scope and contextual categories.
2. Safety review rejects deceptive, illegal, discriminatory, exploitative or mission-incompatible campaigns.
3. The ad service returns a small candidate set matching the current content context and coarse eligibility rules.
4. Selection and frequency capping occur with the least personal data possible; some preference logic may run on-device.
5. The client shows a clear Sponsored label and a "Why this ad?" panel listing the actual factors used.
6. Impressions and conversions are measured through signed events, aggregation thresholds, short retention and fraud controls.
7. Eligible revenue creates ledger entries for the creator pool and the operator allocation. Material adjustments are visible in aggregate.

Ad-free subscription

The ad-free plan should remove sponsored inventory and provide convenience benefits, but it must not buy stronger privacy. A portion of subscription revenue can be allocated to creators based on eligible watch time, with minimum aggregation thresholds and no sale of individual viewing histories. YouTube Premium similarly distributes membership revenue to creators based on viewing, showing that subscriptions and creator payouts can coexist. [R02]

Legal baseline in the European Union

The Digital Services Act applies obligations to online platforms and hosting services, including user reporting mechanisms, advertisement transparency, complaint channels, protection of minors and restrictions on targeting based on sensitive data. The European Commission states that users should be told why an ad is shown and who paid for it, that sensitive-data targeting is banned, and that profiling/personal-data based targeting of minors is prohibited. [R12]

Policy default

Design the stricter contextual system as the global default instead of creating a privacy-respecting EU product and a surveillance product elsewhere. Local law may still require specific notices, age controls, tax treatment or prohibited-content rules.

Commercial limits

- Do not promise that contextual ads will immediately match incumbent revenue per impression. Test demand and pricing honestly.
- Start with direct sponsor sales to mission-aligned brands; do not integrate a surveillance ad exchange merely to fill inventory.
- Place a maximum ad load in the charter and publish changes.
- Never suppress organic reach to coerce creators into buying promotion.
- Do not accept political advertising in the initial product. Revisit only after legal, transparency and societal-risk capability exists.
- Require creators to label paid sponsorships, gifts and affiliate relationships clearly.

7. Privacy, security and trust architecture

Privacy is an architectural constraint

The strongest privacy promise is not "trust us with everything." It is "we deliberately do not possess most of the information that could be abused." GDPR data-protection-by-design guidance emphasises early technical and organisational measures, data minimisation, short retention, limited accessibility, pseudonymisation and encryption. [R11]

Separate the data domains

Domain	Design rule
Identity	Use stable internal identifiers, strong authentication, minimal recovery data and separate privileged access.
Social graph	Store only what the feature requires; make export and deletion behaviour explicit.
Public media	Encrypt in transit and at rest; use signed URLs and provider separation. Public viewers can see public content.
Private communications	Do not launch until an end-to-end encrypted design and independent review exist.
Advertising	Keep contextual campaign data separate from account identity; no cross-service dossier.
Analytics	Use aggregates, sampling and short retention. Avoid third-party SDKs that create an external user graph.

Domain	Design rule
Payments	Use regulated providers and isolate KYC/tax data from product analytics.
Moderation	Restrict access, record reasoned actions and retain evidence only as required for safety, appeals and law.
Keys and secrets	Use managed or self-hosted secret controls, rotation, least privilege and audited access.

Encryption boundaries

	Be precise about the word encrypted A public short video cannot be end-to-end secret from the service while the service transcodes, scans, recommends, moderates and distributes it to the public. Use transport encryption, encryption at rest, access separation and content-addressed storage for public media. Reserve end-to-end encryption for genuinely private communications whose keys remain with endpoints.
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Operational telemetry policy

A reliable service needs enough observability to diagnose crashes, latency, failed uploads, fraud and attacks. The rule should therefore be no behavioural-surveillance telemetry, not no measurements of any kind. Publish a data inventory that identifies every event, purpose, retention period and access role.

Telemetry class	Examples	Default retention
Service health	latency, error rate, queue depth, crash signature	Aggregated long term; raw records days, not years.
Security	failed authentication, rate-limit triggers, incident evidence	Risk-based and documented.
Product quality	anonymous feature success/failure, playback start, accessibility errors	Aggregate or sampled; no advertising identity.
Financial ledger	eligible impressions, adjustments, payout entries	Long enough for audit, tax and disputes.
Behavioural profile	cross-site history, shadow interests, inferred vulnerabilities	Do not collect.

Open source is necessary but not sufficient

- Publish reproducible build instructions and signed releases.
- Generate software bills of materials and dependency provenance.
- Use independent penetration tests and public remediation summaries.
- Publish a security policy, vulnerability contact and coordinated disclosure process.
- Use append-only audit trails for privileged actions and financial allocations.
- Document production deviations from the public repository and minimise private patches.
- Commission privacy and security reviews before activating messaging, minors, payments or federation.

Trust and safety is part of capacity

Disk space is not the limiting factor if reports, appeals or illegal-content notices cannot be handled. The capacity system must count trained moderation hours, response times, language coverage, investigator workload, support backlog and incident-response readiness alongside compute and bandwidth.

- Start with 18+ invited users and original/licensed media.
- Provide block, mute, report and appeal from the first alpha.
- Create explicit policies for harassment, threats, fraud, non-consensual intimate imagery, child sexual abuse material, impersonation, spam and dangerous illegal content.
- Use automated tools to prioritise or detect known risks, but require human review for consequential decisions wherever feasible.
- Publish moderation statistics, error/appeal rates and material policy changes.
- Budget for copyright and music-rights processes before large creator acquisition.

8. Technical architecture and interoperability

Architectural decision

Build a modular monolith first; design federation seams from day one

A tiny team should not begin with dozens of microservices or a global federation. Build one deployable product core with strict modules, portable data and standard storage interfaces. Split services and activate federation only when load, ownership boundaries or ecosystem demand justify the complexity.

MODULAR FIRST, FEDERATED LATER



Recommended logical architecture. Components can share one deployment initially while preserving clear boundaries.

Proposed initial stack

Layer	Recommended starting point	Reason
Landing and public docs	Static site on Vercel, GitHub Pages or equivalent	Near-zero bootstrap cost; easy contribution and migration.
Web application	TypeScript web stack with server-rendered public pages	Fast iteration and accessible public content.
Mobile	Run a short performance bake-off; choose React Native/Flutter only if native video metrics pass, otherwise native Swift/Kotlin	The decision must be driven by measured feed performance, not framework ideology.
API	TypeScript modular monolith with a high-performance HTTP framework	Contributor accessibility and speed; move verified hot paths to Go/Rust later if necessary.
Database	PostgreSQL	Strong transactions, mature ecosystem and reliable financial/social data handling.
Cache/queue	Redis-compatible cache plus a simple durable job queue	Enough for feed caching and media jobs before a larger event platform.
Media	Direct signed upload, FFmpeg workers, S3-compatible object storage, CDN	Portable, proven and compatible with multiple providers.

Layer	Recommended starting point	Reason
Observability	OpenTelemetry-compatible, self-hosted or privacy-reviewed tools	Operational visibility without third-party behavioural tracking.
Infrastructure code	OpenTofu/Terraform-compatible modules and containers; no Kubernetes until justified	Repeatable deployments without premature platform complexity.
Financial ledger	Double-entry append-only ledger in PostgreSQL	Auditable payouts without blockchain complexity.

Core modules

- Identity and authentication: account, passkey/email login, recovery, sessions, export and deletion.
- Profiles and social graph: profiles, follows, blocks, mutes and relationship portability.
- Media: upload, quarantine, scanning, transcode, variants, captions, thumbnails, storage and delivery.
- Content: posts, comments, likes, visibility, licences and provenance.
- Feed: following, chronological, discovery candidates, user controls and explanation metadata.
- Contextual ads: campaign eligibility, creative review, category matching, frequency controls and aggregate measurement.
- Trust and safety: reports, queues, evidence, decisions, appeals, transparency reporting and legal notices.
- Economics: creator ledger, contributor grants, infrastructure units, invoices, holds, payouts and audit exports.
- Capacity: real-time service headroom, moderation/support capacity, reserve gates and waitlist cohorts.

Interoperability path

Do not invent every protocol from zero. ActivityPub is a W3C decentralised social-networking protocol with client-server and federated server-server APIs. AT Protocol separates personal data servers, relays and application views. PeerTube demonstrates federated video hosting and interoperable instances. Each contains lessons, but none automatically solves EverCommons' advertising, creator economics, moderation, media-cost or polished-consumer-UX goals. [R06] [R07] [R08]

Stage	Interoperability commitment
MVP	Documented export for profile, follows, posts, media metadata, revenue records and moderation records where lawful.
Alpha	Read-only import tools and stable public APIs for authorised clients.
Beta	Signed portable identity mapping and migration tests between two providers.
Ecosystem	ActivityPub and/or AT-compatible gateways after threat modelling, abuse controls and user-experience testing.
Mature network	Independent clients, hosting providers and recommendation services with conformance tests and certification.

Licensing architecture

The open-source licence cannot require all users to donate to climate causes or forbid commercial use while still meeting the Open Source Definition. OSI requires, among other things, no discrimination against

fields of endeavour. Ethical obligations should therefore live in the Partner Charter, certification and trademark licence, not as extra restrictions on the code licence. [R09]

Asset	Provisional licence approach	Reason
Server core	AGPL-3.0-or-later after counsel review	Network operators distributing modified service functionality must provide corresponding source under the licence terms. [R10]
Protocol specifications and schemas	Apache-2.0 or similarly permissive licence	Encourage independent implementation and adoption.
Client applications	GPL/AGPL or a compatible open-source licence chosen after app-store review	Preserve openness while managing distribution constraints.
SDKs and integration libraries	Apache-2.0 or MIT	Reduce adoption friction.
Documentation	Creative Commons Attribution licence	Enable translation and reuse.
Brand and certification marks	Trademark policy, not open-source licence	Anyone may use the code; only compliant organisations may claim official partnership.
Contributions	Developer Certificate of Origin initially	Simple provenance without demanding broad copyright assignment.

AI and recommendation systems

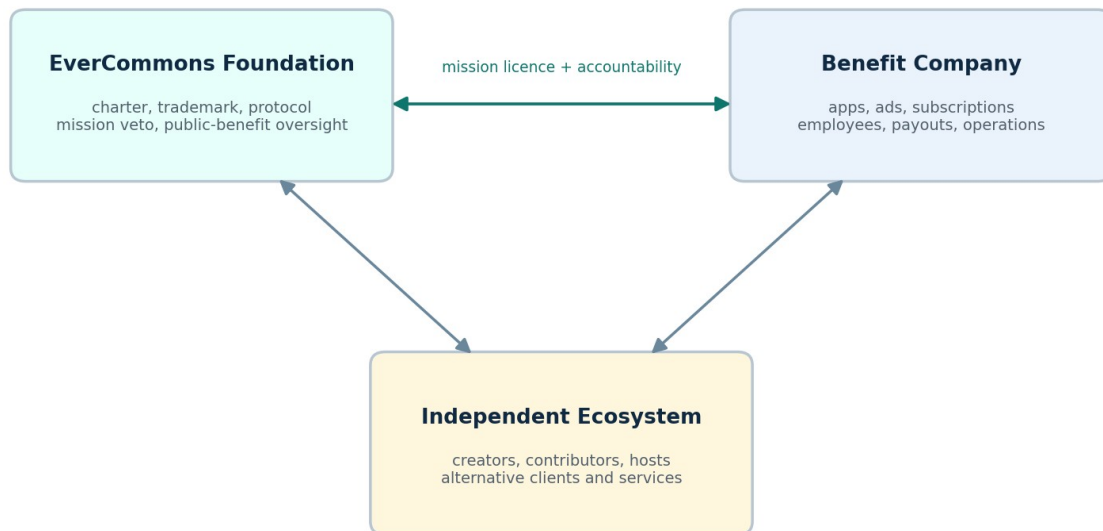
- Ship Following and Chronological feeds before a complex recommendation model.
- Use transparent candidate generation and publish plain-language ranking factors.
- Let users choose feeds and reset or disable personalisation.
- Prefer on-device inference or aggregate signals where it materially improves privacy.
- Do not use private messages or non-public media for model training.
- Do not train on public creator content without a clear legal basis, licence and opt-out/opt-in policy.
- Keep model providers replaceable and benchmark cost, latency, safety, energy and data handling.
- Publish model cards, change logs and environmental metrics for material AI components.

Mistral has argued that AI infrastructure should not be restricted to two or three powerful companies and has published lifecycle metrics covering greenhouse gas emissions, water use and resource depletion for model training and inference. EverCommons should adopt the transparency lesson without claiming that any particular vendor is inherently sustainable. [R18] [R19]

9. Governance, legal structure and founder sustainability

Recommended structure

MISSION ASSETS ARE SEPARATE FROM OPERATIONS



Infrastructure partners advise and contract. They do not own user data or control the mission.

A two-entity structure can make commercial execution possible while protecting mission assets.

The recommended medium-term structure is an Italian operating company, potentially an S.r.l. Società Benefit, paired with an independent nonprofit foundation or association that holds mission-critical assets such as the charter, protocol stewardship and certification/trademark rights. Italy's Società Benefit framework explicitly combines profit with one or more common-benefit purposes in the company statute and requires responsible governance and impact reporting. [R13]

The exact structure requires Italian counsel. It may be simpler to begin as an open project, use an eligible European fiscal host for early transparent donations, then incorporate the operating company when contracts, employment, payments or liability require it. Open Collective and its fiscal hosts illustrate how projects can raise and disburse funds transparently before maintaining their own full administrative structure, subject to eligibility and fees. [R20]

Phased entity plan

Phase	Structure	Trigger
0 - public project	GitHub organisation, charter, prototype; no claims of partnership	Before material data, contracts or revenue.
1 - fiscally hosted initiative	Eligible fiscal host handles donations, invoices and contributor expenses	Small grants or donations before a dedicated entity is efficient.
2 - benefit operator	Italian S.r.l. Società Benefit or counsel-approved equivalent	Employees, advertising contracts, subscriptions, payouts and liability.

Phase	Structure	Trigger
3 - mission foundation	Independent nonprofit/foundation/association owns or controls charter, marks and protocol stewardship	Material brand value, ecosystem providers and governance risk.
4 - steward model	Capped investor rights, mission veto, asset lock or equivalent legal mechanism	External capital or succession requires permanent mission protection.

Board and councils

Body	Proposed composition and power
Operating board	Founder/executive, independent finance/operations director, privacy/safety director and employee representation as the organisation grows.
Foundation board	Independent public-benefit trustees plus creator, contributor and civil-society representation; mission veto over charter, trademark and protocol capture.
Creator council	Elected or randomly selected eligible creators review payout formula changes, creator policy and appeals trends.
Contributor council	Maintainers and non-code contributors review grants, credit methodology and technical-governance proposals.
Infrastructure advisory council	Partners provide technical planning input but receive no ownership of user data or automatic voting power based on spend.
Safety and rights council	Independent experts and affected-community voices review systemic risk, minors, appeals and transparency.

Mission-change control

- Publish proposed constitutional changes at least 90 days before a vote.
- Require a 75% supermajority of the operating board and foundation approval.
- Require creator and contributor council consultation for changes affecting their economic rights.
- Publish legal, economic, privacy and safety impact assessments.
- Never allow a provider or investor contract to bypass the charter secretly.
- Maintain an asset-lock or reversion mechanism for trademark/protocol rights if the operator abandons the mission.

Founder purpose without founder burnout

This can be a serious life project without becoming a promise that personal worth depends on defeating Meta. The founder's purpose is to demonstrate and scale a better set of rules. That purpose is already meaningful at one thousand well-served users.

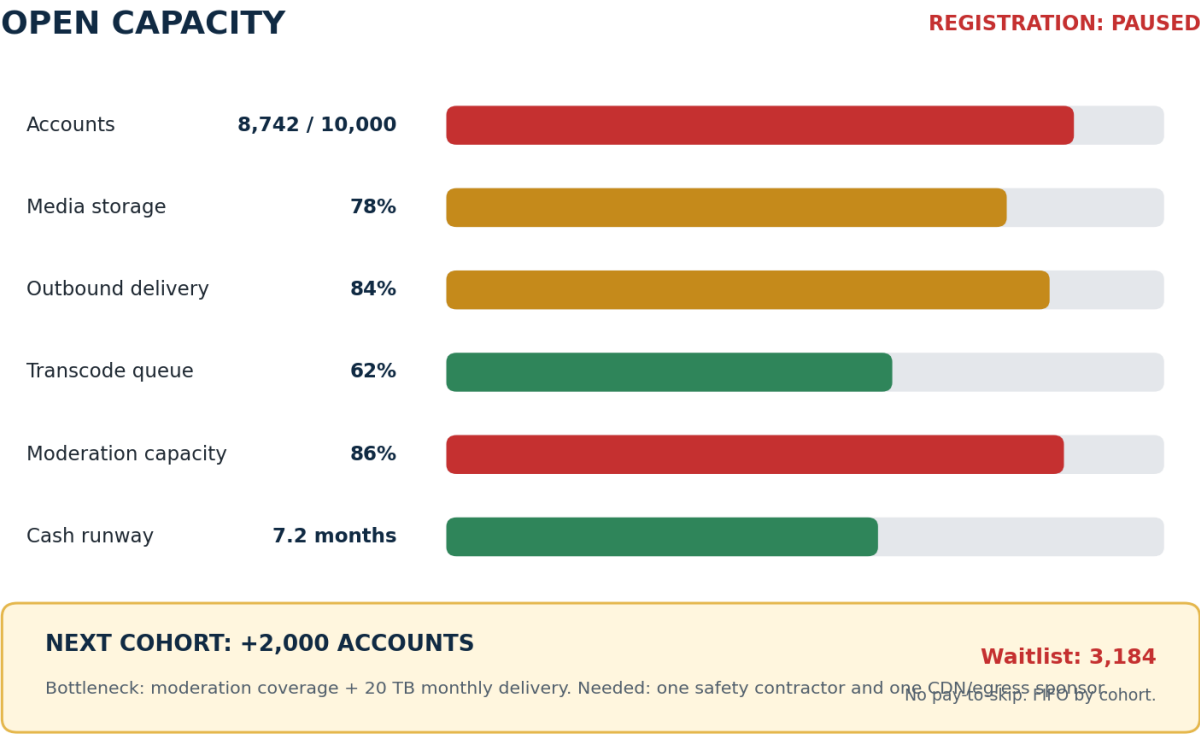
Founder safeguard	Policy
Income	Define the salary level required for stable housing, health, family obligations, rest and reasonable travel. Activate it when the runway gate is met.
Time	Set sustainable working limits and incident rotations; do not build a critical service around one exhausted person.

Founder safeguard	Policy
Succession	Document decision rights and create independent governance before the founder becomes a single point of failure.
Identity	Separate the founder's personal identity from the project brand and allow criticism without treating it as betrayal.
Wealth	Comfort and security are legitimate. Extraordinary extraction is constrained by reserve, payout, mission and surplus policies.
Exit	A future departure should not permit source closure, user-data sale or mission reversal.

Steward-ownership models formalise the idea that profits are a means for mission and long-term development rather than the sole end, while legal implementations differ by jurisdiction. This is a useful design reference for counsel, not a ready-made structure. [R16]

10. Capacity-gated growth

Grow only as fast as the ecosystem can serve people well



Illustrative public capacity dashboard. Real thresholds must be based on measured p95 demand and operational readiness.

Registration should pause before any critical resource becomes saturated. This reverses the conventional venture model of acquiring users first and finding a sustainable business later. EverCommons obtains safe capacity, admits a cohort, measures real usage, earns or raises resources, expands capacity and admits the next cohort.

Capacity is multidimensional

Capacity dimension	Gate examples
Accounts and database	connection limits, storage growth, backup/restore time, replication lag
Media storage	hot storage, backup copies, retention, deletion throughput
Delivery	monthly egress, CDN hit rate, regional latency, provider concentration
Transcoding	queue wait, CPU/GPU hours, failed jobs, peak upload burst
Trust and safety	reports per moderator hour, queue age, language coverage, appeal delay
Support	open-ticket age, account recovery and creator payout support
Security	on-call coverage, incident readiness, patch backlog, abuse rate
Financial	cash runway, committed credits, payout liabilities, tax reserve
Legal and rights	notice handling, copyright queue, data-subject requests, age controls

Draft gate algorithm

	Safe account capacity For each critical dimension, estimate available monthly capacity divided by measured p95 consumption per active account. The safe network capacity is the minimum of those values multiplied by a safety factor, initially 0.80. The next cohort is the smaller of available headroom and the moderation/support onboarding limit.
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State	Threshold	Action
Green	All critical dimensions below 70%; reserve and staffing gates pass	Open the planned cohort and continue measurement.
Amber	Any critical dimension 70-85%, support queue rising or provider concentration high	Slow invitations, acquire capacity, optimise, recruit safety/support.
Red	Any critical dimension above 85%, reserve gate fails or service-level breach persists	Pause registration; maintain waitlist; publish bottleneck and remediation.

Waitlist rules

- Use genuine operational scarcity only. Never fake a full network for marketing.
- Collect the minimum waitlist data and delete stale entries on a published schedule.
- Default to first-in, first-out admission by cohort, with any research, regional or accessibility cohort clearly disclosed.
- No pay-to-skip and no celebrity or billionaire priority for personal access.

- A donor may fund capacity for many people, but does not purchase a better account, algorithmic reach or governance vote.
- Publish the exact bottleneck and the type of help needed: storage, delivery, moderation, legal review, cash reserve or engineering.

Capacity sponsorship

Concrete partner proposition

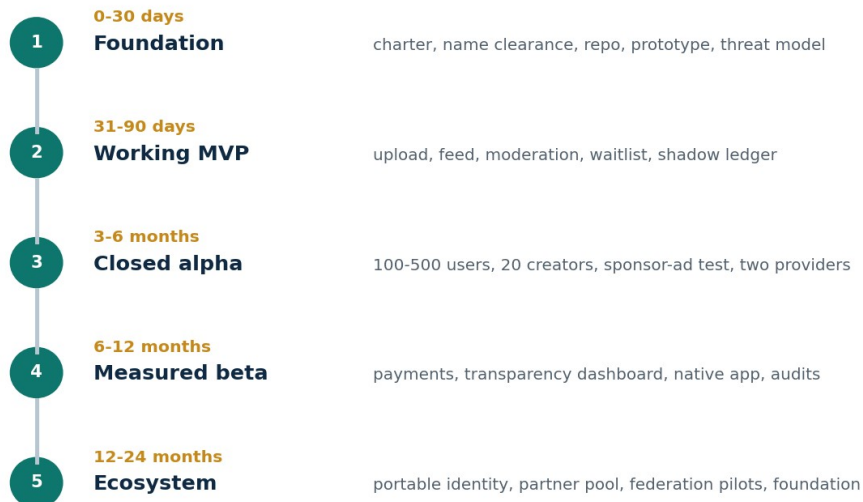
"There are 18,000 people on the waitlist. This audited package of 100 TB storage, 30 TB monthly delivery and two moderation contractors enables the next 5,000-account cohort. Your contribution will be publicly attributed for twelve months under the Partner Charter."

This is stronger than asking for unspecified goodwill. It provides a measurable outcome, clear duration and public proof. It also avoids promising that a provider can support unlimited growth forever.

11. Launch and partnership plan

Evidence-gated roadmap

EVIDENCE-GATED ROADMAP



Move to the next phase only when performance, safety, economics, privacy and capacity gates pass.

Dates are planning ranges, not promises. Each phase requires explicit exit criteria.

The first 30 days

1. Reserve the provisional project name only after a formal collision and trademark review; keep EverCommons as the internal working name meanwhile.
2. Create the public GitHub organisation and publish the manifesto, Founding Charter, Code of Conduct, security policy and contribution guide.

3. Build a one-page campaign site with the mission, economic loop, waitlist and GitHub link. Label services accurately as Built With, not partners.
4. Publish RFC-0001 describing the MVP, privacy boundaries, modular architecture, data inventory and exclusions.
5. Create an interactive design prototype for onboarding, feed, upload, creator dashboard, "Why this ad?" and capacity dashboard.
6. Recruit five founding contributors across mobile, backend, design, privacy/safety and community operations.
7. Interview ten creators and five potential advertisers. Ask about cross-posting, payout clarity, brand safety and contextual campaigns.
8. Prepare a concise infrastructure request with measured pilot needs rather than asking for unlimited free hosting.
9. Obtain an initial Italian legal consultation covering entity timing, privacy roles, terms, content liability, advertising and payments.
10. Set a personal founder sustainability budget and a decision gate for when full-time work becomes financially responsible.

Days 31-90

- Ship a working closed MVP: account, upload, transcode, playback, profile, follow, feed, comments, report/block, waitlist and admin queue.
- Use 100-500 invited adult testers and 20 founding creators; do not accept public uploads at uncontrolled scale.
- Run a performance bake-off for mobile framework selection using the real feed and mid-range devices.
- Operate the creator and infrastructure ledgers in shadow mode to validate formulas without promising cash that does not exist.
- Publish weekly reliability, capacity, security and moderation learning notes.
- Apply to relevant open-source/startup credit programmes while maintaining a migration plan.
- Contact at least ten providers with specific contribution packages and a draft Partner Charter.
- Complete a basic threat model, privacy impact assessment and external architecture review.

Alpha-to-beta gates

Gate	Minimum evidence before expansion
Product	Stable playback and upload, measured performance targets, accessible core flows, low crash rate.
Safety	Reports processed within policy, appeals functioning, trained coverage for launch languages, incident playbook tested.
Privacy	Data inventory, retention controls, no third-party surveillance SDKs, export/deletion tested, DPIA reviewed.
Economics	Real ad or sponsorship test, verified cost per watch-minute/upload, cash reserve and payout-liability controls.
Creators	At least 20 active creators, repeat posting, rights-clean content and evidence that cross-posting is practical.
Infrastructure	At least two viable providers or a tested migration; backups restored successfully.
Governance	Published charter, conflicts policy, financial reporting and independent advisor involvement.
Legal	Terms, privacy notice, DSA/GDPR process, tax/payment and content-rights advice suitable for the launch scope.

Community recruitment

A Reddit or Hacker News post should not say only "help us build a better internet." It should show a live prototype, state what has been decided, disclose what is uncertain and list finite tasks.

Weak request	Actionable request
"Developers wanted"	"Review the signed-upload threat model and propose tests for replay and quota abuse."
"Designers wanted"	"Improve the creator onboarding flow while preserving the one-screen privacy explanation."
"Need servers"	"Provide 5 TB S3-compatible storage and 10 TB monthly egress for a six-month, 500-user pilot under the Partner Charter."
"Creators join us"	"Cross-post five original videos, join two feedback calls and test the revenue dashboard."
"Help translate"	"Review 220 interface strings from English into Italian and document terminology decisions."

Provider outreach structure

1. Who we are: a public, open-source, privacy-preserving social-media pilot based in Europe.
2. What exists: repository, prototype, contributors, waitlist, capacity model and governance charter.
3. What we need: a defined quantity of service, region, term, SLA and support.
4. What the partner receives: measured attribution, case study, partner status, and/or pool participation under transparent terms.
5. What the partner never receives: user-data ownership, exclusivity, secret algorithm influence or permanent equity.
6. How either party exits: migration period, data export, deletion verification and public status update.

Naming recommendation

	EverCommons - provisional winner "Ever" signals durability and a project designed to outlast one company or founder. "Commons" signals shared infrastructure, responsibility and benefit rather than a free-for-all. The name scales from social media to messaging, cloud, identity and AI. The tagline explains the economics: "The digital ecosystem that gives back."
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Avoid OpenSocial as the main brand. OpenSocial already names a historical public specification and remains present in active repositories, creating confusion and search collision. [R21]

Naming criterion	EverCommons assessment
Mission fit	Excellent: durable digital commons and shared responsibility.
Ecosystem breadth	Excellent: not limited to one app category.

Naming criterion	EverCommons assessment
Memorability	Strong, though the meaning of "commons" should be explained to mainstream users.
Pronunciation	Straightforward in English; test in Italian and target launch languages.
Basic collision screen	No obvious direct software/social-platform match found in a limited web search on 21 August 2026. This is not legal clearance.
Legal/domain certainty	Unknown until EUIPO, WIPO, national company registry, domain, social-handle and app-store review.

12. Metrics, risks and decision gates

North-star system

EverCommons should not optimise one engagement metric. A healthy digital commons requires a balanced scorecard. Growth is allowed only when the product, economics, rights, safety, resilience and public benefit remain healthy together.

Dimension	Core metrics
Product quality	video start time, frame stability, crash-free sessions, upload success, accessibility defects
Community	active creators, repeat creators, meaningful comments, blocks/reports, cohort retention
Creator economics	eligible revenue, payout rate, median creator payout, dispute rate, payout latency
Contributor economics	paid contributors, concentration, maintenance coverage, grant outcomes, appeal rate
Infrastructure	cost per 1,000 watch-minutes, storage per active user, provider concentration, migration-test age
Privacy	data fields collected, raw-event retention, privileged access, deletion/export success, incidents
Safety	report rate, queue age, action accuracy, appeal reversal, language coverage, severe incident response
Financial	runway, restricted funds, payout liabilities, revenue diversity, reserve-policy compliance
Environment	SCI per 1,000 watch-minutes/uploads, energy source evidence, water/material disclosures where available
Public benefit	1% accrual, recipient verification, disbursement, outcomes and conflict disclosures

Environmental accounting

Use environmental metrics to improve engineering decisions, not only to fund offsets. The Green Software Foundation's Software Carbon Intensity specification defines a rate of carbon emissions per functional unit and includes operational and embodied emissions; offsets do not reduce the SCI score. EverCommons can

report metrics such as grams CO₂e per 1,000 watch-minutes and per 1,000 processed uploads, with disclosed boundaries and assumptions. [R15]

- Prefer efficient codecs and bitrates without damaging accessibility or quality.
- Avoid unnecessary autoplay preloading and retain only justified media variants.
- Measure cache effectiveness and data movement; egress is both a cost and environmental concern.
- Extend hardware life and account for embodied impacts where data exists.
- Compare providers using measurable evidence, not a single renewable-energy marketing badge.
- Publish AI energy, water and resource estimates for material model use when credible data is available.

Principal risks and mitigations

Risk	Failure mode	Primary mitigation
Cold start and network effects	Creators have no audience and users have no content.	Cross-posting, founding creators, curated cohorts, topic communities and import tools.
Poor UX	Mission attracts interest but product feels slow or unfinished.	Performance budgets, native bake-off, small scope and public quality gates.
Video cost explosion	Egress, variants and storage grow faster than revenue.	Capacity gates, efficient encoding, CDN strategy, provider pool and cost-per-watch metrics.
Moderation failure	Abuse grows faster than trained capacity.	18+ closed start, report/appeal from day one, safety gate and gradual cohorts.
Copyright and music	Unlicensed media creates liability and payout conflict.	Original/CC/licensed audio first; rights metadata and notice process.
Ad revenue weakness	Contextual inventory earns less than expected.	Direct sponsor sales, subscriptions, tips, managed services, donations and smaller sustainable scale.
Fraud and payout abuse	Bots manufacture impressions or contribution scores.	Holds, anomaly review, identity/payment checks, aggregate measurement and appeals.
Provider capture	A large sponsor becomes operationally indispensable.	Multi-provider abstraction, concentration limits, quarterly migration tests and no governance purchase.
Mission drift	Future leaders close source or sell data.	Foundation control, supermajority, asset lock, public notice and trademark licence.
Founder burnout	One person becomes the product, fundraiser and incident response.	Sustainable pay, role boundaries, contributors, succession and evidence-gated scope.
Legal underestimation	GDPR, DSA, tax, employment, advertising or content rules are missed.	Specialist counsel, DPIA, limited launch scope, documented process and reserve.
Celebrity dependency	Launch plan assumes famous supporters arrive.	Treat celebrity support as upside; build a working niche community without it.

Stop, continue and scale decisions

Decision	Evidence
Continue discovery	Creators and users understand the mission; at least five credible contributors commit to finite work.

Decision	Evidence
Build alpha	Prototype tests well; rights and privacy scope is viable; personal founder runway is responsible.
Accept external users	Security, moderation, terms, backups and incident response pass review.
Turn on ads	Advertiser safety review, transparency, aggregate measurement and creator ledger are tested.
Turn on payouts	Cash reserve, tax/KYC, fraud holds, disputes and accounting controls are operational.
Open next cohort	All capacity gates remain below threshold after prior cohort stabilises.
Federate	Portability works, abuse model is understood and at least two independent implementers are ready.
Build a second app	The first product has stable leadership, economics, safety and a reusable platform layer.

Final recommendation

Proceed - but prove the model in a deliberately small system

Create the public charter and prototype now. Build one excellent short-video product. Admit only the cohort the team can serve. Publish the costs and formulas. Recruit creators by asking them to cross-post, not defect. Approach providers with concrete capacity packages. Pay the founder and contributors when the runway supports it. Protect the mission before success makes it valuable enough to capture.

Appendix A. Draft Founding Charter

This draft is suitable for discussion and repository publication after legal and community review.

1. Purpose

EverCommons exists to build and maintain open, private, interoperable and economically sustainable digital services that serve users, creators, contributors and the public interest.

2. Universal privacy

The organisation will not make essential privacy protections conditional on payment.

3. No sale of people

The organisation will not sell personal data, operate a cross-site tracking network or use covert fingerprinting to create advertising profiles.

4. Open core and protocol

Mission-critical software and specifications will remain available under approved open-source licences, subject to clearly identified security exceptions of limited duration.

5. User freedom

Users will receive documented export, deletion and migration paths, and the organisation will oppose technical lock-in.

6. Transparent money

Revenue definitions, allocation formulas, aggregate payouts, provider contributions and material changes will be published.

7. Fair participation

Creators and eligible contributors will participate in economic value according to published rules, due process and anti-fraud controls.

8. Replaceable providers

No infrastructure, AI, payment, advertising or communications provider may receive ownership of user data or become contractually irreplaceable.

9. Capacity-aligned growth

The network will pause registration when technical, safety, support, legal or financial capacity falls outside published limits.

10. Safety and rights

The organisation will maintain reporting, reasoned enforcement, appeals, transparency and age-appropriate safeguards.

11. Public benefit

At least 1% of annual revenue will be reserved for independently verified environmental and public-interest causes, with published recipients and conflicts.

12. Fair work

Founders, employees and maintainers may be paid well. Precarity is not required for public-interest technology.

13. Mission lock

Material changes to privacy, openness, portability, public benefit or economic participation require public notice, supermajority approval and independent mission oversight.

14. Honest communication

The organisation will distinguish technologies it uses, projects that inspire it, community contributions and official contractual partnerships.

15. Evidence

The organisation will publish regular reports on product quality, safety, privacy, finances, infrastructure concentration and environmental intensity.

Appendix B. Draft Partner Charter

Eligibility

A partner may be a commercial company, cooperative, university, public body, nonprofit or individual operator. The partner does not need to release all of its own software as open source. It must comply with the following terms for the service contributed to EverCommons.

1. Process data only for the contracted purpose and documented instructions.
2. Do not sell, profile, enrich, reuse or train models on EverCommons user data or content without a separate explicit agreement and lawful basis.
3. Use documented standard interfaces and provide export/migration assistance.
4. Accept non-exclusivity and multi-provider operation.
5. Disclose subprocessors, service regions, security controls and material environmental data available.
6. Notify security incidents promptly and cooperate in remediation and user/regulator obligations.
7. Provide verifiable usage, availability and contribution data for pool calculations.
8. Do not claim ownership of users, social graph, protocol, recommendation policy or community governance.
9. Do not condition service on political, advertising or algorithmic influence outside the published contract.
10. Support termination, deletion verification and public status correction when the relationship ends.

Recognition and payment

- Sponsor recognition states the verified service, value or capacity and the contribution period.
- Revenue-share payment is based on audited Infrastructure Contribution Units and contractual caps.
- Unused credits, failed capacity and inflated retail valuations do not earn units.
- Partner status can be suspended for security, privacy, service or mission breach.
- Contribution does not buy account priority, organic reach, user data or board control.

Appendix C. Research basis and sources

Research was reviewed on 21 August 2026. Programme terms, prices and laws can change. Primary and official sources were preferred. This bibliography supports the factual context; the project design and allocations remain recommendations requiring testing and counsel.

- [R01] **Signal.** [Privacy is Priceless, but Signal is Expensive](#) Published 16 Nov 2023; operating-cost transparency and privacy funding.
- [R02] **YouTube Help.** [YouTube partner earnings overview](#) Current revenue-share definitions for Watch Page, Shorts and fan funding; accessed 21 Aug 2026.
- [R03] **Vercel.** [Open Source Program](#) Current programme page; credits and eligibility can change.
- [R04] **DigitalOcean.** [DigitalOcean Startups](#) Current programme conditions and credit limitations; accessed 21 Aug 2026.
- [R05] **DigitalOcean.** [Spaces Object Storage Pricing](#) Example current storage and transfer pricing; not a project quote.
- [R06] **World Wide Web Consortium.** [ActivityPub Recommendation](#) Decentralised social networking protocol.
- [R07] **AT Protocol.** [The AT Stack](#) Architecture overview for PDS, relays and application views.
- [R08] **PeerTube / Framasoft.** [PeerTube documentation](#) Federated video-platform reference.
- [R09] **Open Source Initiative.** [The Open Source Definition](#) Open-source licence requirements, including no field-of-use discrimination.
- [R10] **Free Software Foundation.** [GNU Affero General Public License v3](#) Network copyleft licence text; obtain specialist advice before adoption.
- [R11] **European Commission.** [What does data protection by design and by default mean?](#) GDPR Article 25 overview.
- [R12] **European Commission.** [New rules to protect your rights and activity online in the EU](#) DSA overview for illegal-content reporting, minors, advertisements and complaints.
- [R13] **Italian Ministry of Enterprises and Made in Italy.** [Societa Benefit - Cosa sono](#) Official Italian overview of benefit companies.
- [R14] **1% for the Planet.** [1% for the Planet membership](#) Revenue-based environmental contribution model.
- [R15] **Green Software Foundation.** [Software Carbon Intensity Specification v1.1](#) Carbon intensity per functional unit, including operational and embodied emissions.
- [R16] **Purpose.** [What is steward ownership?](#) Purpose-orientation and self-determination concepts.
- [R17] **European Commission.** [Digital Commons EDIC launches to advance Europe's technological sovereignty](#) Published 11 Dec 2025; Italy among founding members.
- [R18] **Mistral AI.** [Our contribution to a global environmental standard for AI](#) Lifecycle reporting for GHG, water and resource depletion.
- [R19] **Mistral AI.** [Mistral Compute](#) Infrastructure sovereignty position; not an endorsement of EverCommons.
- [R20] **Open Collective.** [Open Source Collective](#) Fiscal-hosting example for open-source projects; eligibility and fees apply.
- [R21] **OpenSocial.** [OpenSocial Specification repository](#) Prior use of the OpenSocial name and specification.
- [R22] **GitHub.** [GitHub Sponsors](#) Existing mechanism for supporting open-source contributors and organisations.

Name-screen note

A limited exact-name web search for "EverCommons" on 21 August 2026 did not identify an obvious active social-software or digital-commons project using the exact mark. Search results are incomplete and are not evidence of trademark or domain availability. Before public use, commission searches of EUIPO, WIPO, Italian and target-market company registries, common-law usage, domains, social handles, package registries and app stores.

Research conclusion

The external evidence supports the feasibility of the building blocks: privacy-preserving services can operate at scale but require substantial funding; creator revenue can be shared through explicit formulas; open-source credit and fiscal-host programmes exist; federated social and video protocols already provide lessons; European policy is moving toward digital commons and sovereignty; and established frameworks exist for benefit companies, revenue-based environmental giving and software-carbon measurement. The unproven part is the specific EverCommons combination. That is exactly what the small, measured pilot must test.

Immediate next actions

1. Approve the working mission and the non-negotiable principles; record unresolved questions rather than hiding them.
2. Commission a formal EverCommons name, trademark, company, domain, social-handle and app-store clearance before public branding.
3. Open the public repository with the manifesto, Founding Charter, Partner Charter, Code of Conduct, security policy and contribution guide.
4. Publish a one-page campaign site and an interactive prototype showing feed, creator dashboard, contextual-ad explanation and capacity waitlist.
5. Recruit a small founding circle covering product engineering, design, privacy/security, moderation and creator/community operations.
6. Build the cost, capacity, rights and threat models for a 100-user closed alpha before accepting public uploads.
7. Approach several replaceable infrastructure providers with one measured request, while keeping a cash-funded fallback and migration plan.
8. Recruit the first creators for non-exclusive cross-posting, operate a shadow revenue ledger and open each new cohort only after the gates pass.

The first milestone

A trustworthy 100-user pilot with excellent playback, clear moderation, a public cost ledger and one real capacity sponsor is more valuable than a million-person promise.

Build the proof

EverCommons does not need to defeat every technology giant before it matters.

It needs to prove that one polished network can be free to use, commercially sustainable, open source, private by architecture, fair to creators and contributors, independent of any single provider, and beneficial to the wider world.

The first public promise

We will grow only as fast as we can remain fast, private, safe, financially responsible and faithful to the commons.

Working name: EverCommons

Tagline: The digital ecosystem that gives back.

Document version 0.1 - 21 August 2026